

CW0625017 6/17/05 9:15 AM Page 17

THE AMBUSH

BY DONNA TARTT

Before I met Tim — who, in spite of everything I'm about to tell you, would be my best friend for the next four or five years — my mother warned me on the way over to his grandmother's house that I had to be nice to him. "I mean it, Evie. And don't mention his father."

"Why?" I said. I was expecting to hear: *Because his parents are divorced.* (This was why I had to be nice to John Kendrick, who I couldn't stand.)

"Because," my mother said, "Tim's father was killed in Vietnam."

"Did he get shot?"

"I don't know," said my mother. "And don't you ask him."

I was eight, and small for my age. Tim was seven. As my mother and his grandmother chatted above my head in the doorway of his grandmother's house, we looked at each other silently, from a distance, like two little animals: me, standing in the bright doorway between the grown-ups; Tim, from the remote wood-panelled darkness of the hallway. I couldn't see him clearly, but he was my height, which pleased me.

My mother put her hand on my shoulder. "Did you know," she said to me, in the stagey voice she used when she spoke to me in front of other people, "that Mrs Cameron is good friends with your grandmother?"

I twisted away, shyly, under the broad pink-gummed smile of Mrs Cameron. Every old lady in town was friends with my grandmother: if she didn't play cards with them, she went to church with them. The card-playing friends dyed their hair and dressed more stylishly, with cocktail rings and handbags that matched their shoes. The church friends were stouter, and friendlier to children; they wore flower prints, and pearls instead of diamonds, if they wore jewellery at all. Mrs Cameron was clearly a church friend: compact, pony-built, with shiny pink cheeks. Her hair was grey and she had very black eyebrows, but they were naturally black, like a man's — not drawn on with pencil.

"Hello, honey," she said to me. "I've got a nice swing-set out in the backyard. Tim, why don't you take her out to see it?"

As soon as we were alone, the very first thing Tim said to me was: "My dad's dead."

"I know," I said.

He didn't seem surprised that I knew. We stood facing each other, over the water hydrant in his grandmother's backyard: a long way away from the house.



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He was a snub-nosed, well-rounded little boy, burned brown from the sun, with eerie yellow-brown eyes and a plump, satisfying tummy like a rabbit's. He reached inside his shirt and showed me some dog tags on a metal chain.

"These were his," he said. "They're mine now."

The dog tags had a name stamped on them that was Tim's last name, and they said US MARINES, but didn't look like they really belonged to his dad. They looked like something he'd had made at a fair or at a booth at the mall.

"See, my dad was trying to chase down this Vietnamese that shot his friend," said Tim. "And then the Vietnamese killed him, too. I can act it out for you if you want. I'll be my dad and you be his buddy. OK. Here we are in the jungle." He walked away a few steps, and then looked back at me. "You're walking with me. Keep up. We can't get separated."

"What's my name?"

"Hank," he said, with gratifying swiftness. "Hank Madigan. All right, here we go. We're walking down the path towards camp, we're talking. OK?"

"OK," I said. I caught up with him, and together we crept — heads down, a pair of cautious infantrymen — towards a tangle of shrubbery at the edge of his grandmother's yard. He'd said we were supposed to be talking, and I wondered if maybe I should ask something soldierly ("How far to camp, sir?") but Tim had such a grim, determined look on his face that I was slightly afraid to say anything at all, even in character. He ploughed straight ahead, towards the shrubbery, while I kept my eyes on the side of his face.

"Now — all of a sudden, these shots come out the jungle, eck eck eck BOOM. You're dead," he said, after a moment or two when I still stood looking at him.

Obediently I clutched my chest and crumpled to the grass. Tim — gratifyingly — dropped to his knees beside me and began to shake my shoulders.

"Oh my God!" he said. "Stay with me, Hank! You can't die, you son of a bitch!" I grimaced and tossed my head from side to side in agony as Tim — in a desperate effort to revive me — pounded on my chest. I was impressed by his profanity, but even more impressed that he had taken the Lord's name in vain on my behalf.

Far away, from the back porch, Tim's grandmother called out to us in a thin, irritating voice: "Do you all want lemonade?"

"No," shouted Tim, plainly annoyed. He sat back on his heels, on the grass, ➔

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The Guardian Weekend | June 25 2005 17

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